prospects. They will act accordingly. Unless Test cricket is willing to fight back, and reproduce itself as a marketable product, it will die a death. To do so, it needs help from the authorities, who must utilize the well-funded promotional expertise that is being employed in other forms of the game.

Perhaps it is time to embrace the thought that less can be more. A more strategic approach to Test cricket, with fewer, better-promoted matches, would restore a sense of occasion and reduce pressures on players who are having to shoehorn in commitments to other, more lucrative forms of the game. Test cricket is changing, in any case.

It is not necessarily a bad thing that very few matches last the full five days, because longevity gives it authenticity, but run rates are higher, and games are moving along quicker. The skill of defensive batting, which once produced days in which teams plodded to 220–2, has been replaced by greater attacking intent, which results in being 350–6 at the close. It is more exciting to watch.

I've nothing against franchise cricket, but I wonder whether it fulfils a sportsman's basic instinct, to leave something behind. Another team, another game, another town. It all seems a bit ephemeral. Does it create the same sense of satisfaction? Yet, to argue against myself, I appreciate how much work goes into it. You cannot approach it half-heartedly, because it will eat you up.

Yuvraj concentrated my mind in a similar fashion to Tendo, by hinting at the importance of history, despite my natural scepticism. It still seems unreal to consider that I'm the fifth highest scorer of all time. No England player has more Test runs, more hundreds, more catches, more consecutive matches, more games as captain.

What's in a name? What's in a number?

Comparing players across generations is one of my biggest bugbears, because I question its relevance. Cricket is a game that encourages romanticism and nostalgia, but looking back and thinking 'it was better in my day' is self-delusory because, rather like Formula 1, it is now a different sport, tailored to a different time. Making judgement calls between Juan Manuel Fangio, Ayrton Senna and Lewis Hamilton is as futile as adjudicating between Denis Compton, Viv Richards and Joe Root.

Modern life has been accelerated out of all recognition. Life stories are told in minutes on social media. My hunch is that, in thirty years' time, the pioneers of T20, like KP and Gayle, AB de Villiers and Buttler, will be